Where You Are: What Matters Most, the Third Part of Step One

The nine steps of the Family Care Roadmap, with yours marked, and what comes after it.

A conversation with your wife about what matters most to her can seem to stand on its own. It has a place. It's the third part of the first of nine steps, and nothing after it runs on a schedule.

This page shows the whole road, where you are on it, and what comes next, whenever your family gets there.

Phase 1 · Care Assessment

Understand the person, the family, and the situation.

1 **Discover** Current Situation → Concerns & Challenges → Goals & Priorities
You finish with: Family Care Starting Profile

You are here. You're on the third part of this step, Goals & Priorities: what your wife wants to keep, in her words, and what the family hopes for and can honestly offer. You finish it with her preferences and the family's priorities written down, the unanswered questions still visible, and an agreement about how you'll continue the conversation.

2 **Assess** Health & Function → Safety & Support → Lifestyle & Preferences
You finish with: Personal Care Baseline and Preferences Profile

3 **Define Needs** Needs & Risks → Care Requirements → Priorities & Recommendations
You finish with: Care Needs Profile and Future Action Roadmap

Phase 2 · Care Planning

Determine what good care should look like and prepare to put it in place.

4 **Explore Options** Care Setting → Provider/Facility Fit → Selection & Decision
You finish with: Preliminary Care Options Research and Decision Plan

5 **Build the Plan** Health & Personal Care → Daily Life & Quality of Life → Monitoring & Response
You finish with: Personal Care Planning File and Future Review Templates

6 **Prepare the Transition** Preparation → Move & Admission → Continuity of Care
You finish with: Transition-Readiness File and Future Handoff Template

Phase 3 · Care Management

Coordinate the plan, review what happens, and prepare the family to take the lead.

7 **Coordinate** People & Responsibilities → Communication & Handoffs → Care-Plan Alignment
You finish with: Care Team, Communication, and Meeting-Readiness Kit

8 **Monitor** Monitor → Identify & Escalate → Review & Adjust
You finish with: Monitoring, Advocacy, and Review-Readiness Kit

9 **Hand Off** Educate → Empower → Support

You finish with: Starter Family Care Playbook and Future Support Plan

What this step produces

A written starting point: what your wife has said she wants to keep, what each of you hopes for and worries about, where those agree and where they differ, and the questions nobody can answer yet. It is a family's notes, organized. It isn't a plan, and it can change.

Coming back to it is part of the design. The Institute for Healthcare Improvement tells care teams that conversations about what matters should take place at multiple points instead of once. The National Institute on Aging says a calm discussion like this is most productive when there is not an emergency. [1] [2]

What happens next

This topic closes step one. With the two parts before it, the current situation and the family's concerns, it makes up the Family Care Starting Profile. The step after it is called Assess, and it looks at health and function, safety and support, and lifestyle and preferences.

In the Plan Ahead track there is no date on any of this. Your family takes the next step when it's ready to.

Who is involved, by role

- Your wife: her own account of what matters to her and what she'd want to keep. Hers comes first.
- You and the kids: asking, listening, writing down, and saying honestly what each of you could offer.
- Her doctor and other clinicians: any question about her health. Nothing in this part of the step needs one, but that is where such a question goes.
- Your care consultant: asks her directly what is important to her, keeps her wishes separate from the family's, and helps the family see where it agrees, where it differs and what it can realistically contribute.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. Families move through the steps at their own speed.

Ready for the next step?

You know where this conversation sits and what follows it. The care interview is how the rest of step one gets written down: when you're both ready, it walks you through your wife's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Family Care Roadmap's own. The points about returning to the conversation and talking when there is no emergency come from the sources below.

1. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities